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Business at the Summit

Pushing India's industrial growth needed visionaries with exceptional entrepreneurial zeal. Here are Top 10 pioneers who immensely contributed to the country's wealth creation

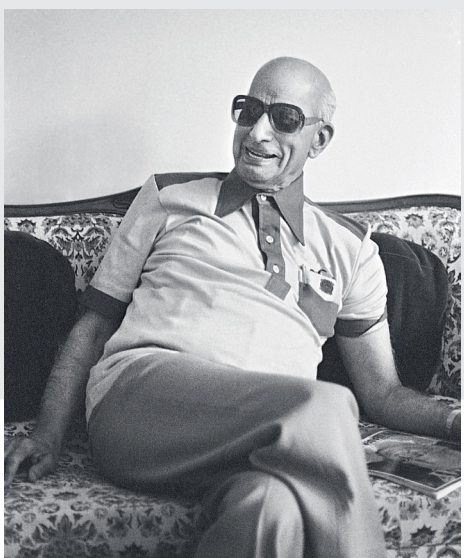


NAMAS BHOJANI

G.D. Birla *(1894-1983)*

Birla Group patriarch

Ghanshyam Das Birla, or GD as he's often referred to, was one of the architects of India's industrial growth. By the time GD was born, on April 5, 1894, the family was well established. Later, as a young man, he wanted to diversify the family business into manufacturing. GD left for Calcutta in Bengal Presidency and began independently as a jute broker. In 1918, he established Birla Jute Mills, and with an investment of Rs 50 lakh in 1919, the Birla Brothers Ltd was formed. In the 1940s, he ventured into the territory of cars and established Hindustan Motors. After Independence, Birla invested in tea and textiles through a series of acquisitions of erstwhile European companies. He also expanded and diversified into cement, chemicals, rayon and steel tubes. Although business always absorbed his mind, his heart was from the beginning captured by Mahatma Gandhi and India's freedom struggle.



J.R.D. Tata *(1904-1993)*

Former Chairman, Tata Sons

J.R.D. Tata was a nationalist as well as an internationalist at the same time. Apart from Air India and Tata Consultancy Services, JRD steered the group into new avenues that included Tata Motors, Titan Industries, Tata Tea and Voltas. From the 14 enterprises he inherited, JRD built an empire comprising 95 companies by the time he retired in 1988, taking the business of the Tata Group from $100 million when he took over to over $5 billion. Under his guidance as a trustee, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust established Asia's first cancer hospital, the Tata Memorial Centre, in Bombay in 1941. JRD also founded the Tata Institute of Social Sciences, the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research and the National Centre for Performing Arts besides many other institutions.